NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦J

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 4 ♥ Q J 10 7 4 ♦ 7 5 2 ♣ K 6 4 2	
♠ K Q J 9 6 3 ♥ 8 ♦ 9 3 ♣ A J 8 7	N W E S	♠ 10 8 2 ♥ A 5 2 ♦ Q J 10 6 4 ♣ 10 9
	♠ A 7 5 ♥ K 9 6 3 ♦ A K 8 ♣ Q 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♠	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥		
All Pass			

3♥ by North
Lead: ♠10

When the opponents overcall your 1NT opener a 2NT bid by partner is lebensohl. You have been instructed to make a relay bid of 3♣, and you do so. Partner now bids 3♥.

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The 3♥ bid is a sign-off, ala the lebensohl methods. So you pass.

South would be playing the hand in 3♥.

North plays 3♥. East leads the ♠10. You win the first trick with dummy's ♠A.

You just have to pull trumps so none of your winners get ruffed. So play a ♥ at trick 2. East wins and plays another ♠ which you ruff.

Continue with two more rounds of trumps. Then play to a ♣ honor. Unless the ♣s split 3-3 you will lose two tricks in the suit but your fourth ♣ can be ruffed with dummy's last trump. Of course you also have the ♦ loser which you couldn't avoid.

A lot of hands are like this, nothing to the play and everybody who plays the contract will probably take the same tricks.

The purpose of the hand is to point out the advantages of using **lebensohl** convention when the opponents interfere. It got you to a makeable 3♥ contract.

And just look at the EW hands. They can easily make 3♠.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 5 2 ♥ Q 3 ♦ J 9 6 ♣ Q J 10 9	
♠ K J 10 8 4 ♥ A 7 6 2 ♦ K ♣ 7 4 3		♠ 9 7 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ A Q 7 2 ♣ A K 5 2
	♠ 6 3 ♥ J 10 9 8 ♦ 10 8 5 4 3 ♣ 8 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
3♠	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♥J

Partner bids Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 2♦. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner bids Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 2♦. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner's bidding is crystal clear. He has described a hand with at least 11 points, which has 4 ♥s and 5 ♠s.

The decision is yours, and with no 8-card Major suit fit you decide on 3NT.

East plays 3NT. On South's ♥J opening lead North plays the ♥Q.

On South's ♥J opening lead North plays the ♥Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

You must establish some ♠ tricks which means you will be finessing through South. Since South can get the lead at most once in ♠s you should not hold up in ♥s. The problem with a hold up is that North may pocket one ♥ trick and then switch to ♣s, a suit in which you are no better off.

Win the ♥K and play your ♠9, letting it ride. Suppose it holds the trick. Continue with another ♠, taken by North's ♠Q.

North cannot hurt you. If he has a ♥ to play, then ♥s will have broken no worse than 4-2 and you will lose two ♥s and two ♠s.

If North plays any other suit you have a double stopper and can establish ♠ tricks before they can set up a winner of their own.

Suppose you let North hold the ♥Q. That's one trick for the bad guys.

North could play a ♣, knocking out one of your ♣ A K. When North won his first ♠ he would establish the ♣s, and when he took the second ♠ he could cash 2 ♣ tricks.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 10 9 8
♥ A K 2
♦ 9 5
♣ 8 7 4 2

♠ K 4 2
♥ Q J 9 8 5 3
♦ Q 7 2
♣ Q



♠ Q 7 3
♥ 10
♦ 10 8 6 4 3
♣ J 10 9 5

♠ J 6 5
♥ 7 6 4
♦ A K J
♣ A K 6 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♥	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥Q

Partner's 2NT is lebensohl, requesting that you bid 3♣. You obey and partner now bids 3♥.

Partner's 2NT is lebensohl, requesting that you bid 3♣. You obey and partner now bids 3♥.

The cue-bid is Stayman, asking if you have 4 ♠s. However, since it was a DELAYED cue-bid it also shows stopper(s) in the opponent's overcalled suit. Since you do not have 4 ♠s you go ahead and bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT.

West naturally attacks in his suit, leading the ♥Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

There are several possibilities for extra winners. The ♦Q might drop - or the finesse might work, providing one winner. The ♣s might split 3-2, giving you one extra winner. The ♠ honors might be split (or West might hold both) so the double finesse would give you two winners. Since your minor suit hopes require that BOTH of them work, your best bet is the double ♠ finesse.

You do not need to hold up on the ♥ because you will be finessing twice into East, and he cannot possibly have more than two ♥s, probably only one. Come to your hand with a ♣, play the ♠J and let it ride. East wins the ♠Q and plays another ♣. Win this one and finesse the ♠ again. When this finesse works you can return to your hand with a ♦ and repeat the finesse.

The double finesse has a 75% chance of success since it only requires that West hold either the ♠K, ♠Q, or both.

Even if East held both honors you would **STILL** have established one ♠ winner and would have the possibility of a ♦ finesse.

Board 4
North Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K Q J 8 6 4 ♥ 9 2 ♦ Q 8 7 ♣ 9 4	
♠ A 10 9 ♥ K Q 6 4 ♦ A 9 5 2 ♣ A 5		♠ 5 2 ♥ A 7 3 ♦ K 10 4 3 ♣ K J 6 2
	♠ 7 3 ♥ J 10 8 5 ♦ J 6 ♣ Q 10 8 7 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♠	Pass	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠K

Partner's 1NT overcall shows 15-18 points and guarantees a ♠ stop. With 11 points and no 4-card ♥ suit you say 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠K. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

You need just one more winner. It could come from a finesse of the ♣J. It could come from a 3-3 ♥ split. It could come by establishing a fourth card in ♦s.

Most important for now is the ♠ lead? Do you hold up?

Yes you should hold up. In fact you might as well hold up twice since you aren't contemplating a throw-in of North. Holding up twice will protect you in the unlikely event that North made his 2♠ bid with a 5-card suit.

Both the ♥ possibility and the ♣ possibility will either work or not, so you can save them for later. Your highest percentage chance is the fourth ♦, but here you must be careful. You must try to establish the ♦s without allowing North to get the lead. It is actually pretty easy. Just play a small ♦ from your hand and when North plays low insert the ♦10. South wins the ♦J but cannot harm you with his return.

When the remaining ♦s fall you have established your ninth trick.

Suppose North inkles out what you are trying to do and inserts his ♦Q when you play the low ♦ toward dummy?

If he does that he hands you all four ♦ tricks!

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 10 2 ♥ A 8 ♦ A K 7 3 ♣ 9 8 6 2	
♠ 7 ♥ Q J 9 6 3 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ K 10 5 3		♠ K Q 5 ♥ K 10 4 ♦ J 10 9 5 ♣ J 7 4
	♠ J 9 8 6 4 3 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ 6 2 ♣ A Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♠
All Pass			

3♠ by North
Lead: ♦J

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner tells you that he has only invitational strength, but has at least 6 ♠s. The ♠s are fine by you, but with only 15 HCP you decide to pass.

North plays 3♠. East leads the ♦J. UhOh. Maybe you should have bid game.

Loser List: ♠ = ? : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = ?

If the ♠s are 2-2 there will be only one loser in that suit. And maybe the ♣ finesse will work.

Don't get too optimistic too early. If you play ♠A and another ♠ you could go down. Remember that you only counted one ♥ loser - that means you MUST ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Win the ♦ lead and play ♥A and another ♥ before you touch trumps.

After this there is nothing the defense can do to stop you ruffing one ♥ in your hand.

Just suppose for an instant that you had played ♠A and another.

East would have taken the second ♠, then pulled your last ♠. When the ♣ finesse failed you would make only 8 tricks.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ J 9 5 2 ♥ Q J 5 ♦ 9 2 ♣ 10 9 7 4	
♠ K Q 8 6 3 ♥ 6 2 ♦ K 7 3 ♣ K 6 2	N W E S	♠ A 10 ♥ K 7 4 3 ♦ A 6 5 4 ♣ A Q 5
	♠ 7 4 ♥ A 10 9 8 ♦ Q J 10 8 ♣ J 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦Q

With 12 points and a 5-card Major you transfer partner to that Major. You bid 2♥. Partner bids 2♠. Now what do say next?

With 12 points and a 5-card Major you transfer partner to that Major. You bid 2♥. Partner bids 2♠. Now what do say next?

You must insist on game, but since partner could have a doubleton ♠ you do so by bidding 3NT to give him the choice.

He chooses 3NT by passing.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♦Q. Do you win the first trick or holdup?

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 8

A holdup wouldn't hurt you since South would retain the lead. But it probably wouldn't help you much either since you do have 2 stoppers in the suit. You obviously need to establish at least one more winner in ♠s so you won't have to depend on the ♥A being with North. Need it be said that ♥s is the suit you are worried about and North is the Danger hand? Let's say you win the first trick with dummy's ♦K.

Suppose you play ♠A, then ♠ K Q. If they split 3-3 you will be soooo happy because you will make at least 10 tricks. But if North shows out on the third ♠ you will be pretty happy because you can give up a ♠ to South and still make at least 9 tricks. But if South shows out on the third ♠ you could be in deep trouble. You would have to give North the lead to establish an extra ♠ winner, and he might very well lead through your ♥K.

There is a great safety play to protect against a 4-2 ♠ split. Play a low ♠ from dummy and finesse the ♠10. South may win with a doubleton ♠J but you will still make the contract.

With this layout the safety play finesse actually works and you make an overtrick.

But visualize the ♠J and ♠7 transposed. If you don't make the safety play it is true that the ♠J will fall. BUT, North will still take the fourth ♠ and when he gets in he will return the ♥Q.